BIG FOOD TRUTHS · BF02

What America calls bread.

Bread needs four ingredients. Here's what one classic US white loaf lists.

BREAD

4

ingredients

Flour

Water

Salt

Yeast

The Real Bread Campaign says bread can be made with as few as three: flour, water and salt.

WONDER CLASSIC WHITE

15

ingredients on the label. Open the brackets and you count more than 30 names.

Unbleached enriched flour (wheat flour, malted barley flour, niacin, reduced iron, thiamin mononitrate, riboflavin, folic acid), water, **sugar**, yeast, calcium carbonate, wheat gluten, soybean oil, salt, dough conditioners (one or more of: sodium stearoyl lactylate, calcium stearoyl lactylate, monoglycerides, mono- and diglycerides, distilled monoglycerides, calcium peroxide, calcium iodate, DATEM, ethoxylated mono- and diglycerides, enzymes, ascorbic acid), vinegar, monocalcium phosphate, citric acid, cholecalciferol (vitamin D3), soy lecithin, **calcium propionate (to retard spoilage)**.

5 g of added sugar in 2 slices. Sugar is ingredient number 3.

Too sweet to be bread

In 2020, Ireland's Supreme Court ruled that the bread in Subway's heated sandwiches wasn't "bread" under Irish tax law. Its sugar was 10% of the flour's weight, and the law's limit was 2%. (Bookfinders Ltd v Revenue Commissioners, 2020.) It was a tax ruling, not a health one.

HOW TO READ A BREAD LABEL

1. Count the ingredients. Bread can be made with four.
2. Check the first three. Ingredients are listed by weight, so sugar or syrup in the top three is a lot.
3. Look for Added Sugars on the Nutrition Facts panel, per serving.

WHAT I BUY

Ezekiel 4:9 Sprouted Grain Bread, from the freezer section. It lists 11 ingredients, mostly sprouted grains and lentils. It's the only bread in my house. KZ

Sources, accessed Oct 9 and 14, 2026. Wonder Classic White Bread (Flowers Foods): current label via Kroger, UPC 0007225001137 (kroger.com). Real Bread Campaign, "What is Real Bread?" (sustainweb.org/realbread). Supreme Court of Ireland, Bookfinders Ltd v Revenue Commissioners [2020] IESC 60 (courts.ie). Ezekiel 4:9: Open Food Facts 0073472001202. Labels change, so check the loaf in your hand. General education about food labels, not medical advice. No brand reviewed or endorsed this page.